

Reading Strategies:

Main Idea

Stated/Implied

Identifying the Main Idea in a Text

The main idea answers the question,

- “What is the author’s one *most* important point about the topic?”
 1. Must always **contain the topic** (the word, name, or phrase that tells who or what the paragraph is about)
 2. Must always **make complete sense** by itself (even if you couldn’t read the rest of the paragraph)
 3. Must be a general sentence that **sums up the details** in the paragraph

- Most paragraphs have **topic sentences** that indicate what they are about. Supporting details prove the value of the main idea.

For example

- **Homeless people have many problems. In winter, it's hard to stay warm and it gets too hot in summer. It's also hard to keep things safe without a home. Worst is the lack of privacy.**
- **Topic sentence**
- **Homeless people have many problems.**
- **Supporting details**
 1. In winter, it's hard to stay warm
 2. gets too hot in summer
 3. hard to keep things safe without a home
 4. lack of privacy

Supporting
Details =
**Additional
information to
help
understand the
main idea**

Details consists of specific information

- Examples, Illustrations
- Facts and Statistics
- Reasons
- Incident
- Descriptive Details
- Steps or Procedures
- Comparison or Contrast.

also,

- *Who, what, when, where, why, how?*
The answers will be in the details.

- Read the entire paragraph before you decide
- Is it asking about:
 - *The overall main idea?*
 - *The subject?*
 - *The theme?*
- choose the answer that deals with the **entire selection**, *not* just part of the selection.
- Longer selections (textbook sections, essays, articles, and editorials) can have **overall** stated main ideas.
- The main idea is **general**. Details are **specific**.
- **Examples** are **always** details.
- Details are often introduced by *In addition, also, moreover, another, next, then, last, finally*, etc.

What is the
main idea of
the passage?

Homework is a real problem. During free periods in school I go into the special ed. room and staff members read assignments to me. When I get home my mother reads to me. Sometimes she reads an assignment into a tape recorder, and then I go into my room and listen to it. If we have a novel or something like that to read, she reads it out loud to me. Then I sit down with her and we do the assignment. She'll write, while I talk my answers to her. Lately I've taken to dictating into a tape recorder, and then someone — my father, a private tutor, or my mother — types up what I've dictated. Whatever homework I do takes someone else's time, too. That makes me feel bad.

(On Being 17, Bright, and Unable to Read by David Raymond)

Remember:

- Only ONE sentence can be the stated main idea in a paragraph.
- The main idea is NEVER a question.
 - Examples are details that support the main idea, so they cannot be the main idea.
 - Watch for words or phrases authors use to signal their main idea: *the point is, it is important, thus, etc.*

Location of the Stated Main Idea Sentence

Can appear **anywhere** in a paragraph:

- Most often it appears at the **beginning**.
- The next most likely location is at the **end**.
- The third possibility is somewhere else **within** the paragraph.
- Regardless of where it appears, it will have supporting details that explain more about it, by examples, or details to prove it.

Lantern fish live near the bottom of the ocean where it is very dark, so they carry their own lights. The lights look like tiny glowing pearls. They are called photo-phores. A lantern fish can flash its photo-phores on and off.

1. The light looks like tiny glowing pearls.
2. Lantern fish live near the bottom of the ocean where it is very dark, so they carry their own lights.

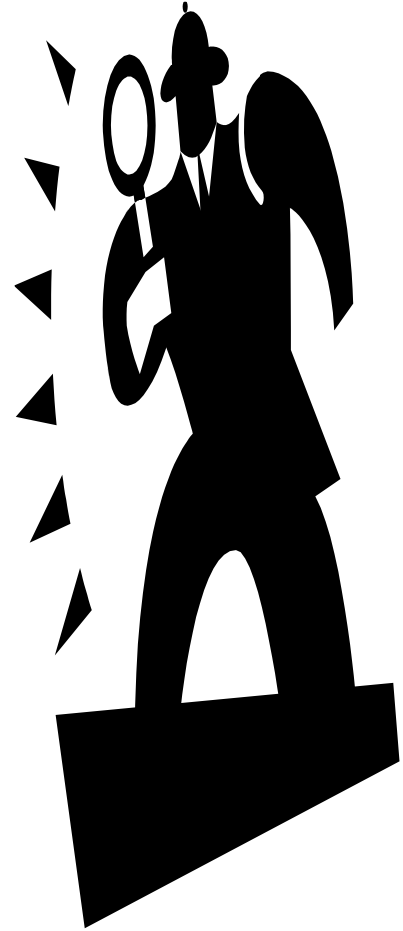
Lantern fish live near the bottom of the ocean where it is very dark, so they carry their own lights. 1-The lights look like tiny glowing pearls. 2-They are called photo-phores. 3-A lantern fish can flash its photo-phores on and off.

Next time you see lightning, count the number of seconds that pass until you hear thunder. The lightning is a mile away for every five seconds that you count. In this way, you can “measure” how far the lightning is from you. Scientists know that the speed of light is faster than the speed of sound. So calculating the difference between the two speeds, they have developed this easy five-second formula.

- The lightning is a mile away for every five seconds that you count.

Implied Main Idea

- The Implied Main Idea is **one that is NOT clearly stated in any one sentence in a passage**. It is only suggested or inferred by the supporting details. The author does not state it directly.
1. Find the topic of the selection.
 2. Decide what the author wants you to know about the topic.
 3. Express the idea in your own words.
 4. An **implied main idea** is not stated directly but is strongly suggested by the supporting details.



Using Supporting Details to Find Implied Main Ideas

- The implied main idea
 - must be general enough to cover all the details,
 - must not be so broad that it is an overgeneralization
 - must not be a sweeping statement that suggests details not given
- To find the implied main idea, create a summary from the supporting details.
- Ask
 1. What is the topic, or subject, of the paragraph?
 2. What are the major supporting details?
 3. Based on the details about the topic, what point or main idea is the author trying to get across?

Figuring Out Implied Main Ideas

The child refused to speak.

The child crossed his arms and turned his back.

The child then threw himself to the floor.

What is the implied general idea?

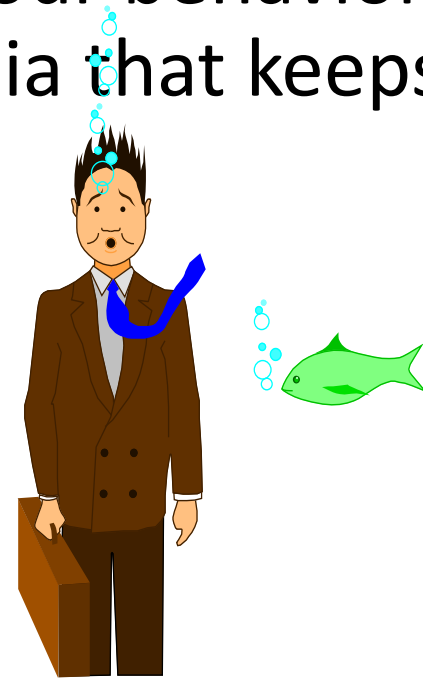
The child is having a Tantrum/outburst/ fit of temper



PRACTICE

What is the implied main idea?

- Fear drains color from our faces, makes our teeth chatter, our hearts pound, our breath quicken, and our knees knock. Fear churns our stomachs, raises goose bumps, and causes jitters. Fear also raises feelings of anxiety and distrust, and may even cause us to change our behaviors. Obsessive fear can become a phobia that keeps us from enjoying life.
- Phobias keep us from enjoying life.
- Fear affects us in several ways.
- Fear is the result of distrust and anxiety.
- Fear affects many people.



What is the implied main idea?



- Green tea has been used for thousands of years in Asia as both a beverage and an herbal medicine. This herbal tea contains **catechin**, which is a type of tannin that acts as an astringent. Research suggests that men and women in Japan who drink five to six cups of green tea each day have much lower rates of cancer than people who do not. Green tea is also thought to lower cholesterol and blood sugar, control high blood pressure, stop tooth decay, and fight viruses. Green tea has even been credited with the power to slow down the aging process.
 - a. Green tea is an ancient herbal drink.
 - b. Green tea has caught the attention of medical researchers.
 - c. Green tea has many positive properties as a health drink.

1.Fire ants are painful and destructive pests. 2.The fire ant earned its name because of its venom. 3.The insect uses a wasp-like stinger to inject the venom, which causes a painful burning sensation and leaves tiny, itching pustules. 4.The ants will swarm over anyone or anything that disturbs their nests. 5.In addition to causing pain, fire ants damage many crops by eating the plants and by protecting other insects that damage crops. 6.Fire ants are attracted to soybeans, eggplant, corn, okra, strawberries, and potatoes.

1. What is the topic of the passage?

- | | |
|--------------|--------------|
| a. Ant bites | b. Fire ants |
| c. Farming | d. Pests |

2. What does the author want you to know about the topic?

- | | |
|--|-------------------------------------|
| a. Fire ants have a wasp-like stinger. | c. Fire ants are pests to farmers. |
| b. Fire ants swarm. | d. Fire ants are painful and pesky. |

3. Which sentence contains the main idea?

- a. 1 b. 2 c. 4 d. 5

Implied Main Ideas

identifying the topic and main idea:

- Remember to look for **repeated words**
- Mark **major supporting details**. Major details are often signaled by **addition words**

Addition Words

one	to begin with	also	further
first (of all)	for one thing	in addition	furthermore
second(ly)	other	next	last (of all)
third(ly)	another	moreover	final(ly)

IMPLIED MAIN IDEAS in Longer Passages

To find the implied central idea in a longer passage, you must ask the same three questions you used to find the main ideas in paragraphs:

- Who or what is this passage about?
(What is the **topic**?)
- What is the **central point** the author is trying to make about that topic?

When you think you know the central idea, you can test it by asking:

- Does *all or most* of the material in the passage support this idea?

Implied Main Ideas

Read the paragraph below. Then answer the question.

All people have a strong need to belong to groups, stemming from evolutionary pressures that increased people's chance of survival and reproduction when in groups rather than in isolation. This need may also be driven by the desire to feel protected against threat and uncertainty in everyday life or to gain a greater sense of personal and social identity. Moreover, people join specific groups in order to accomplish things that they cannot accomplish as individuals. Neither symphonies nor football games can be played by one person alone, and many types of work require team effort. Further, people join groups because of the social status and identity that they offer. An important part of people's feelings of self-worth comes from their identification with particular groups. Even a relatively low-status group can be a source of pride for individuals who are held in high esteem within the group; being big fish in small ponds can make people feel good about themselves, particularly people from individualist cultures. Finally, people may join groups simply because they like the members and want to have the opportunity to interact with them.

What is the **topic** of the paragraph?

Implied Main Ideas

All people have a strong need to **belong to groups**, stemming from evolutionary pressures that increased people's chance of survival and reproduction when **in groups** rather than in isolation. This need may also be driven by the desire to feel protected against threat and uncertainty in everyday life or to gain a greater sense of personal and social identity. Moreover, people **join** specific **groups** in order to accomplish things that they cannot accomplish as individuals. Neither symphonies nor football games can be played by one person alone, and many types of work require team effort. Further, people **join groups** because of the social status and identity that they offer. An important part of people's feelings of self-worth comes from their **identification with** particular **groups**. Even a relatively low-status group can be a source of pride for individuals who are held in high esteem **within the group**; being big fish in small ponds can make people feel good about themselves, particularly people from individualist cultures. Finally, people may **join groups** simply because they like the members and want to have the opportunity to interact with them.

What is the **topic** of the paragraph?

Joining groups

Implied Main Ideas

All people have a strong need to belong to groups, stemming from evolutionary pressures that increased people's chance of survival and reproduction when in groups rather than in isolation. This need may also be driven by the desire to feel protected against threat and uncertainty in everyday life or to gain a greater sense of personal and social identity. Moreover, people join specific groups in order to accomplish things that they cannot accomplish as individuals. Neither symphonies nor football games can be played by one person alone, and many types of work require team effort. Further, people join groups because of the social status and identity that they offer. An important part of people's feelings of self-worth comes from their identification with particular groups. Even a relatively low-status group can be a source of pride for individuals who are held in high esteem within the group; being big fish in small ponds can make people feel good about themselves, particularly people from individualist cultures. Finally, people may join groups simply because they like the members and want to have the opportunity to interact with them.

What is the **implied main idea** of the paragraph?

Implied Main Ideas

All people have a strong need to belong to groups, stemming from **evolutionary pressures that increased people's chance of survival and reproduction** when in groups rather than in isolation. This need may **also** be driven by **the desire to feel protected against threat and uncertainty in everyday life or to gain a greater sense of personal and social identity**. **Moreover**, people join specific groups in order **to accomplish things that they cannot accomplish as individuals**. Neither symphonies nor football games can be played by one person alone, and many types of work require team effort. **Further**, people join groups because of **the social status and identity that they offer**. An important part of people's feelings of self-worth comes from their identification with particular groups. Even a relatively low-status group can be a source of pride for individuals who are held in high esteem within the group; being big fish in small ponds can make people feel good about themselves, particularly people from individualist cultures. **Finally**, people may join groups simply because **they like the members and want to have the opportunity to interact with them**.

What is the **implied main idea** of the paragraph?

People join groups for a number of reasons.

Explanation

Each **major detail** in the paragraph is one reason that people join groups. Note that four of the major details are signaled by **addition words**.

Practice

Identify the main idea

MUST be worded as a complete sentence

1. Always warm up before attempting any strength training exercises. Failure to warm up can cause injuries to cold muscles. Remember to use proper lifting procedures for safety sake. In addition, to avoid harm, make sure that you have a spotter with you if you are using free weights. You can also avoid injury by working within your limits and avoiding the need to show off.
2. One technique to manage stress is self-hypnosis. Another relaxation technique is the “relaxation response.” In this technique, one learns how to quiet the body and mind. Still another way to manage stress is progressive muscular relaxation. This is a procedure in which muscles are contracted and relaxed systematically. Other techniques include yoga, quieting, and diaphragmatic breathing.

3. People who are obese are likely to develop type II, non-insulin dependent diabetes. In fact, 90% of obese people develop this disease. Seventy percent of obese people will develop heart disease, and 33% will develop hypertension. Stomach and breast cancers are also linked to obesity.
4. Eliminating cigarette and tobacco use can reduce one's risk for cardiovascular disease. Increasing physical activity is another lifestyle change that will reduce one's chances of developing heart disease. Another controllable risk factor for heart disease is blood cholesterol level. If we change our eating habits, we can lower the level of cholesterol in the blood, thus reducing our risk of disease. The last controllable risk factor is high blood pressure, a risk factor that can be reduced through changes in lifestyle.

5. If you have a weak background in mathematics, begin each course with the mindset that you will take the course seriously whether or not the grade will count toward your degree requirements. To makeup for a weak background, try to find a teacher who enjoys teaching learning support mathematics classes. If your background is weak, make a point to attend every class and do all of the assigned homework regularly, even if that homework is not collected by the instructor. Also, go to the Math Lab; students who use the math lab generally perform better than students who don't.
6. If you are having trouble with your math instructor, do not use this problem as an excuse of not doing well in the class. If you cannot understand your instructor, ask the teacher to slow down his or her pace and review the textbook's concepts before the teacher presents them in class. If you cannot follow the teacher's notes, work with other students in your class or refer to the math text's study guide to make sense of your notes. If your math teacher will not make time to answer your questions, go to the Math Lab, ask another teacher, or get help from an "A" student.

Possible answers

1. To avoid injury during strength or weight training, one must observe several safety precautions.
2. There are a number of stress management techniques.
3. Many diseases are associated with obesity.
4. There are four risk factors for heart/cardiovascular disease that can be reduced by lifestyle changes.
5. There are several ways that students can overcome a weak background in mathematics.
6. There are a number of ways/strategies to overcome a poor/bad math teacher's instructions.